before interest is charged, experts recommend taking out a personal loan to pay off the high-interest rewards card. Then pay off the personal loan, which will most likely have a lower interest rate. But this should be WORST-CASE SCENARIO.)

Then it came time to use the points for their honeymoon, and what helped was she and her fiancé were flexible about their plans. They just wanted it to be totally paid for by points. Many cards partner only with certain airlines, so she knew she had to fly United because of its partnership with Chase. They looked at the various points deals with different cities: Paris, Mykonos, Rome.

With United, "if you're doing a round trip international flight using points, you can book a free extended layover in another international city." An extended layover meant she and her fiancé could visit another city for free, so they flew from New York to Rome and then from Florence to Barcelona. The second flight was paid for by points. "In the end we ended up spending only $200 in taxes and fees for two round-trip flights to three cities, which was frigging awesome," she said.

So why doesn't everyone do this? Because it's intimidating, and there are huge risks. But if you're going to put your wedding on your credit card, be smart about it: do the math, get only what you can afford, and pick a card with benefits that will actually benefit you.

TAKEAWAYS

° If you're planning a wedding, start with an open conversation with your family and your partner's family about who can/wants to/will pay for what before it gets too out of control.

° Set a budget and stick to it.

° Look at what pieces of your wedding you can get a friend to do for cheap or as a wedding gift. Do you have a friend who bakes? Ask that person to make your cake or other treats for the reception, and you can offer to pay